

Duplex, security and service

HP's **Satish Kumar** on what MSMEs really want from printers

Mithun Mohandas | editor@digit.in

India's MSME engine is getting more digital every quarter, yet paper refuses to disappear. In our conversation with Satish Kumar, Senior Director, India Market, Print Category at HP Inc., the core argument was not that print is making a comeback for nostalgia's sake. It was that MSMEs are still trying to stitch together reliable, secure workflows with limited IT support, and printing and scanning remain practical "glue" in that process.

As Kumar framed it early on, this is bigger than a single device category: "It's not a print solution thing." Instead, he sees a broader opening in how small firms equip themselves end-to-end: "Big opportunity because if I look at the print penetration in India at home, it is less than 3%, right? And if you look at most of the micro SMBs and small businesses, they may not be really IT equipped today, even from an endpoint solution standpoint, PES (Laptops, PCs, desktops and related client services within Personal Systems), PC, print and I think where HP can come in is able to integrate all this and build it on the overall productivity of an enterprise out of the country."

Hybrid MSMEs are now a lived reality

In the modern landscape, small businesses can quickly spread across locations now, and how that changes the way documents move is becoming a central theme for industry leaders. "Because the future is going to be a lot of hybrid eventually," Kumar said. "If a small company starts in Delhi today, it doesn't take, it is not a big effort for them to start branching out to a tier-two, tier-three cities. And that's where hybrid work will come into play."

That hybrid reality is where printing, scanning, and record-keeping become less optional than people assume, acting as the glue that holds these disparate offices together. This is not just about putting ink on paper, but about managing the entire lifecycle of a document. "How you exchange information, how you keep digital records, how you keep physical records. And in printing, scanning is a big part of that," he said, adding a useful nuance for anyone assuming print volumes only go one way: "So while you have pages coming down in certain segments, you have scanning going up on those segments as well."



Satish Kumar
Senior Director, India
Market, Print Category
at HP Inc.

From HP's perspective, the goal is to move away from transactional hardware thinking and towards longer-term service relationships. Kumar called it "building a solution partnership with customers" and connected that to "contractual businesses" as HP approaches SME customers. By shifting the focus to a service-based model, HP aims to provide SMEs with the same level of support and predictable cost structures that were once reserved only for large enterprises.

Auto-duplex as the new baseline standard

HP has been talking about making auto-duplex a standard expectation, and we were curious to understand where that promise actually holds up, especially in India's price-sensitive market where every additional feature is scrutinized for its value proposition.

Kumar drew a fairly clear line between business-oriented devices and typical home needs: "We have HP Smart Tank 700 series, which are auto-duplex or duplex, but those go more into businesses than home because home doesn't have that requirement." He also acknowledged that standardisation in India is uneven, using connectivity as a parallel: "But as duplex becomes standard, like Wi-Fi today is still not a full standard in India. We still have a lot of non-Wi-Fi printers that sell as a segment, right? But as HP, we are working towards moving that market to Wi-Fi. The same thing will happen in duplex..."

The "why" is a mix of sustainability and direct operating cost. "One is that from a customer standpoint, we are sensitive about sustainability," he said. "So auto-duplex saves you paper. It makes printing much more productive from a cost efficiency standpoint, how you use power. So everything kind of gels together when you do that." **d**

Read more on Digit.in:
tinyurl.com/4bnr4j8e